U.S. Government Publishing Office
Publications Help Desk

Style Quick Reference

House style conventions for Publications Help Desk documents, aligned to the GPO Style Manual

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Audience	Publications Help Desk staff, agency publishing liaisons, and anyone drafting a PHD produced document

Training sample. All names, contact details, prices, timelines, and procedures in this document are fictional and were created for a Microsoft Copilot Studio demonstration. They do not represent actual GPO policy.

Document Control

This section records the revision history and the approval chain for this document. Changes to any procedural step, time target, fee, or contact require a new version number and approval by the document owner.

Version	Date	Author	Summary of change
1.0	June 3, 2024	H. Bemis	Initial quick reference
2.0	May 27, 2025	H. Bemis	Added word list; added headings and lists section
2.1	January 14, 2026	H. Bemis	Expanded numbers and dates; added accessibility related style items
3.0	October 1, 2026	H. Bemis	Reorganized into eleven sections; added common errors and pre-submission checklist

1. Purpose and Relationship to the GPO Style Manual

The GPO Style Manual is the authoritative style guide for Federal Government printing and publishing. This quick reference does not replace it. It collects the conventions that come up most often in the documents produced by and for the Publications Help Desk (PHD), states them in one place, and adds a small number of house rules that apply only to PHD documents. Where this quick reference and the GPO Style Manual differ, the GPO Style Manual governs, and the difference should be reported to the Editorial Standards Lead so this document can be corrected.

Use this document when drafting help desk procedures, customer communications, portal text, onboarding material, and any publication produced by PHD design or editorial services. Agency publications follow the agency's own style requirements in addition to the GPO Style Manual; the help desk can answer questions about the conventions here, and refers questions beyond them to the Editorial Standards Lead.

Three habits that prevent most style errors

Read the sentence aloud. If you stumble, the reader will too.

Look up the term in the word list in Section 10 before inventing a spelling.

Use figures and capitals consistently within a document. Consistency within a document matters more than any single rule.

2. Capitalization

Capitalize the following when they refer to the United States or its Government. Use lowercase when the same words are used in a general or non United States sense.

Term	Capitalized when	Example
Federal	Referring to the United States Government	Federal agency; Federal funds; but: a federal system of government (general sense)
Government	Referring to the United States Government as a body	the Government printed the report; but: local government; a foreign government
Nation, National	Used as a synonym for the United States or its Government	the Nation's capital; but: a developing nation
State	Referring to a State of the United States, or in a proper name	the State of Ohio; State law; but: a state of emergency
Congress, Congressional	Referring to the United States Congress in a proper name; the adjective is lowercase in general use	the 119th Congress; Congressional Record (proper name); a congressional district
Department, Bureau, Office	Used as part of, or as a short form of, a specific proper name	the Department of the Interior; the Department; but: a department of the agency
Act	Referring to a specific act of Congress after first mention	the Paperwork Reduction Act; the Act
Administration	Referring to a specific presidential administration	the Administration's budget

Titles of office are capitalized when they immediately precede a name or stand in for a specific incumbent: Director Smith; the Director. They are lowercase when used generically: a director of the office. Job titles at GPO follow the same rule: the Deputy Director, Customer Services; a deputy director.

3. Abbreviations and Acronyms

- Spell out a term on first use and follow it with the acronym in parentheses: Publishing Service Request (PSR). Use the acronym alone after that. If the term appears only once, do not introduce an acronym.
- Do not use periods in acronyms and initialisms: GPO, PSR, PDF, FDLP, CUI. The abbreviation U.S. keeps its periods.
- Use U.S. only as an adjective: U.S. Government; a U.S. agency. Use United States as a noun: published in the United States.
- Spell out State names in running text. Use two-letter postal abbreviations only in addresses that include a ZIP Code.
- Write a.m. and p.m. in lowercase with periods, separated from the figure by a space: 7:30 a.m.
- Spell out the names of months in text and in dates. Abbreviate months only in tables where space requires it.

- Units of measure are spelled out in text (10 inches, 300 pixels per inch) and may be abbreviated in tables and specifications (10 in., 300 ppi).
- Do not begin a sentence with an acronym unless it is a proper name in common use, such as GPO.

Write	Do not write
Publications Help Desk (PHD) on first use, then PHD	P.H.D.
U.S. Government Publishing Office (GPO)	USGPO; U.S.G.P.O.
Federal Depository Library Program (FDLP)	F.D.L.P.
Portable Document Format (PDF) is not required on first use; PDF is a common term	portable document format
7:30 a.m. Eastern Time	7:30AM EST
Washington, DC 20401 (in an address)	Washington, District of Columbia 20401

4. Numbers

Rule	Example
Spell out numbers under 10; use figures for 10 and above	one round of corrections; five business days; 10 business days; 25 sources
When a sentence contains related numbers and any of them is 10 or above, use figures for all of them	The job includes 8 booklets, 12 posters, and 40 forms
Spell out a number that begins a sentence, or recast the sentence	Twelve tickets were escalated. Or: In March, 12 tickets were escalated
Use figures with units of measure, time, money, ages, percentages, and page references	0.125 inch; 2 business days; 75 dollars; 35 percent; page 4
Write percent as a word with a figure	35 percent; not 35%; not thirty-five percent (the symbol is acceptable in tables)
Use commas in figures of four or more digits, except in years, page numbers, and identifiers	12,500 rows; 5,000 units; the year 2026; page 1240; PSR-26-03117
Use figures for ordinals of 10th and above; spell out first through ninth	the ninth revision; the 10th edition; the 119th Congress
Express fractions in words when they stand alone; use figures with units	one half of the run; 0.5 inch
Ranges use the word to in text and a hyphen in tables	10 to 15 business days; 10-15 in a table cell
Money in text uses figures with the word dollars or the dollar sign consistently within a document; PHD documents use the word form in running text and the symbol in tables	75 dollars per round; $75.00 in the Fee Schedule

5. Dates and Times

- Write dates as month day, year: September 29, 2026. Do not use ordinal suffixes (no 29th).
- When a date includes the day of the week, write it as Tuesday, September 29, 2026.
- Write fiscal years as fiscal year 2026 on first use and FY 2026 after that.
- Write clock times with figures and lowercase a.m. or p.m.: 7:30 a.m.; 5:00 p.m. Use noon and midnight rather than 12:00 p.m. or 12:00 a.m.
- Name the time zone in customer communications: 5:00 p.m. Eastern Time. Do not use EST or EDT unless the distinction matters.
- Write durations in business days where the help desk's commitments are measured that way, and say business days explicitly: 2 business days, not 2 days.
- Do not use all numerals for dates in running text (9/29/2026). Numeral dates are acceptable in tables and file names, in the form 2026-09-29.

6. Punctuation

Convention	Guidance
Serial comma	Use a comma before the conjunction in a series of three or more: proofs, estimates, and invoices.
Spacing	One space after a period, colon, or other sentence punctuation.
Hyphens in compound modifiers	Hyphenate two or more words that act together as an adjective before a noun: two-letter abbreviation; 10-page booklet; long-term storage. Do not hyphenate after the noun: the storage is long term.
Hyphens with numbers	3-hole drill; 2-part form; 12-point cover stock.
Colons	Use a colon to introduce a list or an explanation. Capitalize the first word after a colon only if it begins a complete sentence.
Quotation marks	Periods and commas go inside closing quotation marks. Use quotation marks for exact wording of portal labels the first time they are mentioned; after that, use the label without quotation marks.
Parentheses	Keep parenthetical material short. Punctuation goes outside the closing parenthesis unless the whole sentence is inside.
Apostrophes	Use the apostrophe for possession, not for plurals: PSRs, not PSR's; the 1990s.
Ampersand	Spell out and. Use the ampersand only when it is part of a proper name.
Slash	Avoid the slash in running text; write and, or, or per. A slash is acceptable in established terms such as PDF/A.

7. Preferred Spellings and Forms

The following forms are preferred in PHD documents. Most follow the GPO Style Manual; entries marked house rule apply to PHD documents specifically.

Preferred	Instead of	Note
email	e-mail, E-mail	
web, website, webpage	Web site, web-site	Lowercase; one word
online	on-line	
database	data base	
decisionmaking, policymaking, rulemaking	decision-making, policy making	Closed compounds
nonprofit	non-profit	
percent	per cent, %	Symbol acceptable in tables
ZIP Code	zip code, Zip code	
toward	towards	
health care	healthcare	Two words as a noun
workflow	work flow	
fiscal year	financial year	
cost estimate	quote, quotation	House rule: the portal term is cost estimate
proof approval	sign-off	House rule
turnaround	turn-around, turn around (as a noun)	
Publishing Service Request	print request, print order	House rule: the form name
business day	working day, work day	House rule
help desk	helpdesk, Help-Desk	Two words; capitalize only in the proper name Publications Help Desk
liaison	liason	Common misspelling
accessibility	508 compliance (as a general term)	Say Section 508 when referring to the law
alternative text	alt text (in formal documents)	alt text acceptable in checklists and informal notes
saddle stitch, perfect bind, wire-o, coil	stapled, glued	Use the binding terms in the Job Catalog
trim size	paper size, page size	House rule: trim size is the finished size; page size is the file size
pixels per inch	dpi, dots per inch	For images; dpi refers to output devices
setup fee (noun), set up (verb)	set-up fee	

Preferred	Instead of	Note
Section 508	508, Sec. 508	Spell out Section
the GPO Style Manual	the Style Manual, GPO style guide	Use the full name on first use

8. Government and Legal References

- Cite the United States Code as title, U.S.C., and section number, without a section symbol in running text: 44 U.S.C. 1701. Do not italicize.
- Cite public laws as Public Law followed by the Congress number and law number: Public Law 118-31. After first mention, Pub. L. 118-31 is acceptable in tables.
- Refer to the Code of Federal Regulations as title, CFR, and part or section: 36 CFR part 1194.
- Write Executive Order with a number when citing a specific order: Executive Order 14028. Use lowercase for the generic term: an executive order.
- Write the Congress with its ordinal number in figures: the 119th Congress; the 1st session.
- Refer to Members of Congress by title and full name on first mention: Senator Jane Doe; Representative John Roe; then Senator Doe; Representative Roe.
- Do not paraphrase statutory language in a way that changes its meaning. When a customer asks what a statute requires, refer the question to counsel; do not interpret it in help desk documents.

9. Headings, Lists, Tables, and Figures

9.1 Headings

- Number first and second level headings in procedures and manuals (1., 1.1) so that customers can cite them. Do not number headings in short customer communications.
- Use title case for document titles and first level headings; use sentence case for second level headings in customer communications and for table column heads.
- Do not skip heading levels. A third level heading follows a second level heading, never a first level heading directly.
- Keep headings short, ideally under eight words, and make them descriptive rather than clever.

9.2 Lists

- Use a numbered list for steps that must happen in order. Use a bulleted list for items with no required order.
- Introduce every list with a complete sentence or a lead-in phrase ending in a colon.

- Make list items parallel. If one item is a complete sentence, make them all complete sentences and end each with a period. If items are fragments, omit terminal punctuation.
- Limit lists to about nine items. Split longer lists under subheadings.

9.3 Tables and figures

- Give every table a heading row and, in formal documents, a table title above it. Repeat the heading row when a table continues onto a new page.
- Align text left and numbers right within a column. Use the same number of decimal places throughout a column.
- Write a caption below every figure and refer to figures by number in the text (see figure 3).
- Provide alternative text for every figure in an electronic document, following the Section 508 Accessibility Checklist for Publications (GPO-PHD-003).
- Do not use color as the only way to convey information in a table or figure.

10. Plain Language and Tone

Help desk documents are read by busy people who want to finish a task. Write for that reader.

Do	Instead of
Use short sentences, ideally under 25 words	Long sentences with multiple clauses and qualifications
Use the active voice: the help desk reviews the PSR within 1 business day	The PSR will be reviewed within 1 business day
Address the reader as you and the help desk as we in customer communications	Third person references such as the customer should
Say what will happen and by when	Vague commitments such as as soon as possible or shortly
Use the customer's terms and define internal terms on first use	Unexplained internal jargon or system field names
State the answer first, then the explanation	Building up to the answer at the end of a paragraph
Say no clearly and offer the nearest alternative	Hedged refusals that leave the reader unsure
Use must for requirements, should for recommendations, and may for permissions	Shall, will, or ought to for requirements

11. Common Errors

Error	Correction
The job will take 10 days.	The job will take 10 business days from proof approval.
Please submit your print order.	Please submit your Publishing Service Request (PSR).

Error	Correction
The Federal government requires accessibility.	The Federal Government requires accessibility. (Government is capitalized in this sense.)
Rush service costs 35%.	Rush service carries a 35 percent surcharge.
The proof will be sent on the 2nd business day.	The proof will be sent on the second business day.
We received 3 tickets, 15 PSRs, and two calls.	We received 3 tickets, 15 PSRs, and 2 calls.
Contact the help-desk at 7:30AM.	Contact the help desk at 7:30 a.m.
E-mail the file to us.	Email the file to us.
The report is due 9/29/2026.	The report is due September 29, 2026.
Click here for the checklist.	Read the Section 508 Accessibility Checklist for Publications (GPO-PHD-003).
Per the SOP, liaison's must attest.	Under the procedure, liaisons must attest.
The estimate is valid for thirty (30) days.	The estimate is valid for 30 calendar days.

Appendix A: Pre-Submission Style Checklist

Run this checklist before submitting a document for editorial review or release.

1. Federal, Government, Nation, and State are capitalized where they refer to the United States, and lowercase elsewhere.
2. Every acronym is spelled out on first use, and no acronym is used only once.
3. Numbers under 10 are spelled out; 10 and above are figures; related numbers in a sentence are treated alike.
4. Percentages use the word percent with a figure in running text.
5. Dates are written month day, year, with no ordinal suffixes; times use a.m. and p.m. with periods.
6. The serial comma is used in every series of three or more.
7. Compound modifiers before nouns are hyphenated.
8. Preferred spellings from Section 7 are used: email, website, online, decisionmaking, percent, ZIP Code.
9. Lists are parallel and correctly punctuated; steps in sequence are numbered.
10. Headings follow the numbering and case rules in Section 9 and do not skip levels.
11. Every figure has a caption and alternative text; every table has a heading row.
12. Legal citations follow Section 8 and no statute is interpreted.

Appendix B: Where to Get Help

Question	Resource
A convention covered in this document	Ask the Publications Help Desk through the PHD Service Portal, Style and editorial category
A convention not covered here	The GPO Style Manual, current edition; then the Editorial Standards Lead, Harold Bemis
Editorial review of a full document	Order editorial services on the PSR; reviewed at 88 dollars per hour in 15 minute increments
Accessibility related style items	Section 508 Accessibility Checklist for Publications (GPO-PHD-003); Accessibility Specialist, Theo Lindqvist
Portal field names and terms	Publishing Service Request Submission Procedure (GPO-PHD-002), Appendix A